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CORPUS INSCRIPTIONUM SLOVACIAE: A DIGITAL PORTAL OF HISTORICAL INSCRIPTIONS WITH AI-POWERED DETECTION

MIROSLAV ČOVAN – ANNA BARNAU

mirocovan@gmail.com; annabarnau@gmail.com

Jessenius Faculty of Medicine Comenius University in Martin (Slovakia)

INTRODUCTION

- Historical inscriptions constitute a fragile yet invaluable source for the study of medieval and early modern written culture. Exposed not only to weathering but also to vandalism and theft, many inscriptions have already been lost or survive only in archival records.
- The aim of our project is to identify, document, and scientifically analyze epigraphic texts from selected areas of present-day Slovakia (especially from the former counties of Bratislava, Hont, Tekov, Gemer, Spiš, Liptov, and Turiec) dating from the 9th century to 1650. Analytical studies will provide data on written culture in territory of the present Slovakia (e.g. the development of literacy and writing, the influence of national languages, interregional and international cultural contacts, etc.).
- The team of authors is led by the founder of post-Roman epigraphy in Slovakia, Prof. PhDr. Juraj Šedivý, MAS, PhD.

METHODOLOGY

The research combines field documentation, archival investigation, and epigraphic analysis. During field research, inscriptions will be documented using high-resolution digital photography, metric description, and geolocation (GPS). Each inscription will be recorded together with information about its carrier (e.g., bells, tombstones, architectural elements, liturgical objects), material, dimensions, condition, and historical context. The documented inscriptions will be processed according to established epigraphic standards. Each record will include normalized transcription, translation where appropriate, palaeographic description, dating, and historical commentary. These data will serve as the basis for a series of printed regional editions prepared by individual researchers, covering the selected historical counties. All volumes will follow a unified editorial methodology to ensure consistency and comparability across regions. The collected corpus will be subjected to thematic, typological, and comparative analysis. The research will examine the development of epigraphic practices, the linguistic and palaeographic characteristics of inscriptions, and the social and cultural contexts reflected in epigraphic texts. Particular attention will be given to inscription carriers such as medieval bells and to inscriptions recorded in visitation protocols. Analytical results will be published in scholarly articles, conference proceedings, and collective monographs. A digital portal will be created to provide access to the documented inscriptions and their carriers. The portal will include a searchable database and a georeferenced map interface allowing users to explore inscriptions spatially. In collaboration with the Kempelen Institute of Intelligent Technologies (KInIT), the project will also develop a pilot AI-based application designed to automatically detect references to inscriptions in digitized visitation protocols using natural language processing methods. This tool will facilitate the identification of epigraphic material in large archival corpora.

KOŠICE BAPTISMAL FONT

- is the **oldest** inscribed monument (13th /14th century)
  - *+ IN. OLE. QVISQUE LOTVS FIT MUNDI CRIMINE LOTVS VITE ABOLES NOS* (*In this vessel, everyone who is washed is washed from the sin of the world. You deliver us from sin*)
- As being written in Roman majuscule, the content of the text is directly related to the function of the baptismal font, however, it **does not come from the Bible or liturgical texts**.
- **Its author was a member of the clergy**

Figure 1. Baptismal font, late 13th century – early 14th century, St. Elizabeth's Cathedral in Košice

A PROCESSIONAL CROSS

- is the **oldest known epigraphic monument in Košice (13th century,** an import **from German regions)**
  - **I)** *IH(ESV)S NAZ/ARENVS / REX IVD/EORUM*

    (*Jesus of Nazareth, the King of the Jews*)
  - **II)** *+ FLECTERE PENDENTI GENVS HVMANVM REDIME(N)TI* (*Bow down before the crucified one who redeems the human race*)
- although thematically connected to Christ on the cross, the **text is not derived directly from biblical or liturgical sources**.

Figure 2. Detail of an inscription from a processional cross, 13th century, location unknown, East Slovak Museum in Košice.

- ✓ The new findings presented in our research confirm the potential of epigraphic research and its wide-ranging applications.
- ✓ The authors aim to use this multidisciplinary overlap of epigraphy and contribute to the knowledge of not only local history from different perspectives, but also to integrate these new epigraphic findings into the broader context of Central European history.
- ✓ Our digital platform will enable both experts and the public to discover historical inscriptions in the current territory of Slovakia and support further academic research.

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